Portrait Photography Guide

Lighting, lenses, posing and camera settings for photographing people

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1. Introduction to Portrait Photography

Portrait photography captures the personality, mood and character of a person or group. A great portrait is less about technical perfection and more about connection: the expression in the eyes, a natural pose, and light that flatters the subject.

Portraits range from formal studio headshots to relaxed environmental portraits, candid street photography, family sessions and weddings. Each style places different demands on equipment.

Common portrait styles

- **Headshots:** tight framing of head and shoulders for professional or acting use.
- **Studio portraits:** controlled lighting and backdrops.
- **Natural-light portraits:** window light or outdoor light, often with a reflector.
- **Environmental portraits:** the subject in their workplace or home, telling a story.
- **Candid and street portraits:** unposed moments, often with a small, discreet camera.
- **Weddings and events:** a mix of posed and candid images in changing light.

> **Tip:** The most important skill in portraiture is putting people at ease. Talk to your subject, explain what you are doing and show them good frames on the back of the camera.

2. Choosing a Camera for Portraits

Portraits do not require extreme speed. Instead, prioritise image quality, colour and reliable eye focus.

- **Human face and eye detection autofocus.** At wide apertures the depth of field is razor thin; eye AF keeps the nearest eye sharp automatically.
- **Colour science and skin tones.** Cameras differ in how they render skin. Accurate, pleasing skin tones reduce editing time.
- **Dynamic range.** Wide dynamic range preserves detail in backlit scenes and bright windows.
- **Resolution.** 24-45 MP is ideal; it allows cropping and large prints.
- **Sensor size.** Full frame gives shallower depth of field and better low-light quality than APS-C at the same framing.
- **Articulating or tilting screen.** Helps with low and high angles.
- **Silent shutter.** Useful in ceremonies and for candid work.

Burst speed is not a priority

Most portrait work is done at single-shot or low burst rates. 5-10 fps is plenty, which is why portrait-focused cameras often trade speed for resolution and colour quality.

Interchangeable lens versus fixed-lens compact

	Interchangeable lens body	Fixed-lens compact
Flexibility	Swap lenses for any focal length	One fixed focal length
Size	Larger, more intimidating	Small, discreet, relaxed subjects
Cost	Body plus lenses adds up	Lens included
Best for	Studio, weddings, headshots	Street, candid, everyday portraits

3. Portrait Lenses

Focal length changes how a face looks. Short focal lengths used close up exaggerate noses and foreheads; longer focal lengths flatten and flatter features.

Focal length	Typical use
24-35mm	Environmental and candid portraits, groups
50mm	Half-body and full-body portraits; affordable and versatile
85mm	Classic head-and-shoulders; flattering compression
105-135mm	Tight headshots, strong background blur
70-200mm	Weddings and events; flexibility from a distance

Wide apertures (f/1.2 - f/2) create the smooth, out-of-focus background known as bokeh and separate the subject from distractions. They also let in more light indoors.

> **Tip:** On an APS-C body, multiply focal length by about 1.5. A 56mm lens on APS-C frames like an 85mm on full frame.

4. Camera Settings for Portraits

Aperture priority is the most popular mode for portraits because aperture controls depth of field.

Aperture

Aperture	Effect
f/1.2 - f/1.8	Very shallow depth of field; dreamy background; only the eyes sharp
f/2 - f/2.8	Shallow but more forgiving; whole face sharp
f/4 - f/5.6	Groups of two or three people
f/8 - f/11	Large groups, studio work with flash

Shutter speed and ISO

- Keep shutter speed at least 1/(2 x focal length) when hand-holding, e.g. 1/200 s with an 85mm lens.
- In-body stabilisation helps with static subjects but not with subject movement.
- For children and lively subjects use 1/500 s or faster.
- Keep ISO low for clean skin; raise it before letting the image blur.

Focus

- Enable face and eye detection and select the subject's nearest eye.
- Use continuous AF if the subject is moving or you are shooting at f/1.4 where small movements matter.
- Check focus at 100% magnification on the first few frames.

White balance

Shoot RAW and set a custom or Kelvin white balance to keep skin tones consistent across a session.

5. Natural Light Portraits

Natural light is free, soft and flattering when used well.

- **Window light:** place the subject at 45 degrees to a large window for soft, directional light. North-facing windows give the most consistent light.
- **Open shade:** position subjects in shade facing open sky for even, shadow-free light.
- **Golden hour:** warm, low light just after sunrise and before sunset.
- **Backlight:** place the sun behind the subject for glowing hair, and expose for the face.
- **Overcast days:** clouds act as a giant softbox.

Reflectors

A white or silver reflector bounces light back into shadows under the eyes and chin. Gold reflectors add warmth. A reflector is the most affordable lighting tool you can buy.

> **Tip:** Avoid harsh midday sun overhead, which creates dark eye sockets. If you must shoot at midday, use shade or a diffuser.

6. Studio and Flash Lighting

Artificial light gives you complete control. Even one flash or LED panel with a modifier opens up many looks.

Classic lighting patterns

- **Butterfly (paramount):** light high and in front; small shadow under the nose; glamorous.
- **Loop:** light slightly to the side; small shadow loop from the nose; flattering for most faces.
- **Rembrandt:** light at 45 degrees and high; triangle of light on the shadow cheek; dramatic.
- **Split:** light at 90 degrees; half the face in shadow; moody.
- **Broad and short:** lighting the side of the face nearest or furthest from the camera to widen or slim it.

Modifiers

- Softboxes and octaboxes give soft, controllable light.
- Umbrellas are cheap and spread light widely.
- Beauty dishes give crisp yet flattering light for fashion and beauty.
- Grids and snoots narrow the beam for hair and background lights.

A larger light source relative to the subject gives softer light. Moving the light closer makes it softer too.

7. Posing and Directing People

Most people feel awkward in front of a camera. Your direction makes the difference.

- Angle the body 30-45 degrees away from the camera, then turn the face back towards the lens.
- Ask the subject to push the chin slightly forward and down to define the jawline.
- Shift weight onto the back foot for a relaxed stance.
- Give hands something to do: pockets, hair, a prop, or holding each other.
- Shoot from slightly above eye level for a flattering perspective.
- Avoid cutting limbs at joints when framing.

Genuine expressions

- Keep talking; ask questions and listen.
- Shoot between poses; the moment after a laugh is often the best frame.
- For couples and families, give prompts (whisper a joke, walk together) instead of rigid poses.
- Show the subject a great frame early to build confidence.

> **Tip:** For candid street portraits, a small, quiet camera is less intimidating and people behave more naturally.

8. Composition and Backgrounds

- Place the eyes on the upper third line of the frame.
- Leave space in the direction the subject is looking.
- Choose simple backgrounds or blur them with a wide aperture and distance.
- Increase distance between subject and background for stronger blur.
- Watch for objects 'growing' out of heads.
- Use leading lines and frames such as doorways to draw attention to the face.
- Experiment with vertical framing for single subjects and horizontal for environmental shots.

Environmental portraits

Include the subject's surroundings to tell a story: a chef in a kitchen, a musician with an instrument. A 24-35mm lens and a moderate aperture of f/2.8 - f/4 keep both subject and setting readable.

9. Weddings, Events and Editing

Weddings and events

Weddings combine posed portraits, candid moments and difficult light, often in dim churches and reception halls. A full frame camera with clean high ISO, reliable eye AF, a silent shutter and dual card slots is strongly recommended. Many wedding photographers carry two bodies with a 35mm and an 85mm lens.

Editing portraits

- Correct white balance first; skin tone accuracy is the priority.
- Retouch blemishes lightly; keep skin texture natural.
- Brighten eyes subtly and enhance catchlights.
- Use dodge and burn to shape the face.
- Apply consistent presets across a session for a cohesive look.

Cameras with good colour science out of the camera reduce the time needed to correct skin tones.

10. Portrait Buying Checklist

Use this checklist to match a camera to your portrait photography needs.

Question	If yes, prioritise
Do you shoot studio or professional headshots?	Full frame, 40+ MP, accurate colour
Do you love strong background blur?	Full frame with f/1.2 - f/1.8 lenses
Do you shoot weddings or indoor events?	Low-light quality, silent shutter, dual slots
Do you shoot street or candid portraits?	Small fixed-lens compact, quiet shutter
Is budget a concern?	Compact with built-in fast lens, or APS-C plus 50mm f/1.8
Do you photograph moving children?	Reliable eye AF, 10+ fps
Do you shoot outdoors in poor weather?	Weather sealing

Summary

Studio, wedding and professional portrait photographers benefit most from a full frame body with excellent skin tones, wide dynamic range and reliable eye AF at wide apertures. Street and everyday portrait photographers are often happier with a compact, discreet fixed-lens camera with a bright lens, which puts subjects at ease and costs less than a body plus a portrait lens.